



ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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BAFFLING THAT INDIAN BOWLERS HARDLY USED THE BOUNCER AGAINST TRAVIS HEAD

This is Head's **fourth century** against India in the last 18 months or so and not once has he been tested by the short delivery early on.

What a Headache this Travis is turning out to be for India. Every time he comes out to bat against India, the situation is a bit tricky for Australia. He then simply takes the attack by the scruff of its neck and squeezes the life out of it so much so that the shoulders and heads drop visibly.

When Steven Smith was scoring all those hundreds, every bowling unit in the world was trying to find a way to stop him. His exaggerated back-and-across movement, just as the bowler was about to release the ball, made some people believe he would be vulnerable to the one that nips back in.

Some thought he could be bowled around his legs; some felt a leg-slip could get him out glancing because of that across-the-crease movement. Nothing worked. Yes, he did get out leg-before-wicket or caught down the leg-side, but more often after he had got a big score, and he was a bit late with the bat coming down, perhaps due to weariness of the long hours spent at the crease.

The Kiwi fast bowler Neil Wagner tried the bouncer trap, and it worked to some extent. The thing is that bowlers tried, and there were some successes.

Against Travis Head in Brisbane, despite even the former Aussie players suggesting that the bouncer at the start of his innings was a vulnerable area, the Indian bowlers have just not employed the tactic. There was video evidence of it too, being played before the Gabba Test began. Yet, the Indian bowlers hardly ever tried this line of attack. It's been incredibly baffling that no one, including Jasprit Bumrah, has tried this.

Bumrah has one of the best bouncers in the game, one that comes at the helmet like a rocket. Mohammed Shami, among Indian quicks, has the best bouncer, but he is not here in Australia, and Mohammed Siraj, Harshit Rana and Akash Deep have not bowled it as accurately to cause any problems.

Most crucially, there were hardly any bouncers bowled to Head in his first 30 deliveries when he was trying to settle in. This is his fourth century against India in the last 18